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A Shortened Version of the Profile of Mood States

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Abstract: The feasibility of using a shorter version of the Profile of Mood States is examined. Eighty-three cancer patients were administered the Profile of Mood States. The scales' internal consistency (coefficient alpha) and the items' face validity were used as criteria for eliminating items. The number of items was reduced from 65 to 37 and the correlation coefficients between the short and original scales were all above .95, indicating the suitability of the short version for estimating the original mood scale scores in this population.

The Profile of Mood States (POMS; McNair, Lorr, & Dopleman, 1971) has been utilized in many previous investigations in an attempt to assess transient, distinct mood states. The POMS is an adjective checklist consisting of 65 items rated on a 5-point scale that ranges from "not at all" to "extremely". Based on repeated factor analytic studies (McNair et al., 1971) six factors have been derived. The six factors are: Tension-Anxiety, Depression-Dejection, Anger-Hostility, Fatigue-Inertia, Vigor-Activity, and Confusion-Bewilderment.

One of the major advantages in using the POMS is the ease of administration. The completion of the questionnaire usually takes between 3 to 7 minutes for a normal and healthy population. However, when we administered the scale to very ill patients (terminal cancer patients with severe pain) the administration time of the questionnaire was considerably greater (15-20 minutes) and some patients had difficulties completing the scales. In an effort to facilitate the use of the POMS with patients under stress or pain, a shorter version was developed.

Participants were 83 cancer patients with pain complaints who participated in a study designed to assess the natural history of pain in cancer patients and the effectiveness of pain treatments. The study was carried out at the Clinical Sciences Center of the University

of Wisconsin-Madison. There were 23 male and 60 female patients, and the mean age of the patients was 53.6 years ($SD = 11.9$). All patients were administered the POMS (65 items) on an individual basis.

The mean scores of the sample on the POMS scales are presented in Table 1. The scales' means ranged from $\bar{x} = 1.59$ for Fatigue to $\bar{x} = 0.55$ for Anger-Hostility. The other scale means were Tension ($\bar{x} = 1.33$); Vigor ($\bar{x} = 1.39$); Confusion ($\bar{x} = 1.13$), and Depression ($\bar{x} = .91$).

The short scales were formed using the Reliability program from Statistical Package for Social Science (Hull & Nie, 1971). This program assesses the contribution of items to the internal consistency of a scale. Items were eliminated according to a two-fold criterion: (a) the contribution to internal consistency (coefficient alpha) of the scale, and (b) the face validity of the items in relation to the scales.

As can be seen in Table 1, each of the six scales was reduced by two to seven items without losing internal consistency. For some scales like Confusion and Tension the internal consistency coefficients were improved. The total number of items of the POMS was reduced from 65 in the original form to 37 in the short form, and the time needed to administer the scale was reduced to almost half.

To assess the capability of the short scales for substitution of the original scales, the shortened scales were correlated with original ones. The data,

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Table 1
Comparison Between the Original POMS Scales and the Short Form Scales

	The Original Scales			Short Form Scales			Correlation Between the Short & Original Scale
	Number of Items	Internal Consistency Reliability	Mean ¹ Score	Number of Items	Internal Consistency Reliability	Mean Score	
Tension-Anxiety ²	9	.736	1.33	6	.803	1.44	.951
Depression-Dejection	15	.913	0.91	8	.907	1.19	.968
Anger-Hostility	12	.897	0.55	7	.899	0.65	.972
Vigor-Activity	8	.865	1.39	6	.866	1.25	.972
Fatigue-Inertia	7	.886	1.59	5	.872	1.73	.979
Confusion- Bewilderment	7	.736	1.13	5	.819	.99	.961
Total Mood Disturbance	58		4.02	37		4.61	.99
Total Number of Items	65			37			

¹ To adjust for the number of items included in each scale, the mean score of each scale was calculated by summing the items score and dividing by the number of items included in each scale.

² The items included in the short form scales are: Depression = unhappy, sad, blue, hopeless, discouraged, miserable, helpless, worthless; Vigor = lively, active, energetic, cheerful, full of pep, vigorous; Confusion = confused, unable to concentrate, bewildered, forgetful, uncertain about things; Tension = tense, on edge, uneasy, restless, nervous, anxious; Anger = angry, peeved, grovelly, annoyed, resentful, bitter, furious; Fatigue = worn-out, fatigued, exhausted, weary, bushed.

as presented in Table 1 indicates a very high correlation (all above $r = .95$) between the original and the short scales.

Results demonstrate that the POMS can be shortened significantly without losing information or internal consistency and suggest that when there are time limits or patient limitations, the shortened version can be used.

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